E3 Reading – Exam Prep Lesson 1: Main points and purpose – Lesson plan and answers

Learners finish able to say what a whole text and each paragraph is about, and why it was written. These are AC1.1 and AC2.1, two of the criteria learners most often fail.

Materials: Handouts 1A, 1B and 1C, one per learner. Six blank slips of paper per pair.

Activity 1: Why did someone write this? (20 minutes, teacher-led)

1. Write six verbs on the board in a column: *describe, advise, warn, advertise, inform, instruct*. Say each one and have the class repeat it.
2. Give a spoken example of each without naming the verb. Learners call out which verb it is. Use: “Mind the gap” (warn); “Half-price trainers this weekend only” (advertise); “You should register with a GP” (advise); “Turn left at the lights” (instruct); “The class starts at 9.30” (inform); “My street is long and quiet, with a bakery on the corner” (describe).
3. Ask where learners saw English writing on the way to college today. Collect ten examples on the board, such as bus signs, shop windows, texts and letters. For each one, the class decides the purpose and you write the verb next to it.
4. Draw out the language clues and add them to the board: *should* and *it is a good idea to* signal advice; a verb at the start of the sentence signals instructions; *danger, beware, do not* signal a warning; prices and *free, new, best* signal advertising; adjectives and *there is* signal description.
5. Tell learners that one question in the exam always asks this, with four verbs to choose from.

Activity 2: Six short texts (25 minutes)

1. Hand out 1A. Learners read alone for three minutes without writing.
2. In pairs, they choose the purpose of each text and underline the words that helped them decide.
3. Take feedback one text at a time. For each, ask a pair for the answer, then ask a second pair for the clue words. Insist on the clue words every time: the habit of proving an answer is the point of the activity.
4. Extension for fast pairs: change text 3 so that it warns instead of advises.

Activity 3: What is each paragraph about? (30 minutes, teacher-led then pairs)

1. Hand out 1B face down. Tell learners they have 30 seconds to look at it. Turn over, time them, turn back. Ask: What is it about? Who is in it? Accept anything. Praise any correct guess and point out that they got it without reading every word.
2. Teach the method on the board: read the title, then the first sentence of each paragraph, then stop and say the topic in three or four words.
3. Read paragraph 1 aloud. Ask for the topic in four words or fewer. Write suggestions on the board and choose the best together.
4. Pairs now read the whole text and match the headings on 1B to the paragraphs. Warn them that one heading is not needed.
5. Feedback: for each paragraph, ask which sentence gave the answer. Then ask why heading F fits nowhere. The text never mentions cost.

Activity 4: Exam questions (25 minutes)

1. Hand out 1C. Learners answer alone in 12 minutes, in silence, as in the exam.
2. Pairs compare. Where they disagree, each must point to the line that supports their answer.
3. Class feedback. For every question, ask why one of the wrong options is wrong. Example for question 1: option C is true, the shops did throw food away, but it is one detail and not the main idea. Name this trap clearly: a true detail is not the main point.

Activity 5: Write it, swap it, guess it (20 minutes)

1. Give each pair a secret purpose verb on a slip of paper.
2. Each pair writes a two-sentence text about the college with that purpose. Example for *warn*: “The stairs are wet. Please use the lift.”
3. Pairs pass their text to the next pair, who write the purpose and the clue word underneath, then pass it on again. Continue for three passes.
4. Read out four or five texts. The class votes on the purpose. Finish by asking each learner to tell their partner the two things they must do with a purpose question: find the clue words, and choose the verb that fits the whole text.

Answer key, Lesson 1

- **1A:** 1 warn (thieves, keep). 2 advertise (fresh, get one free). 3 advise (should, a good idea). 4 instruct (press, wait, hold). 5 describe (large, tall, it has). 6 inform (will close, date and time).
- **1B headings:** 1 D, 2 C, 3 A, 4 E, 5 B. F is not needed.
- **1C:** 1 B, 2 C, 3 B, 4 C, 5 A.